

about 3,000 words

The Planetarium Tooth
by Douglxss Burley Johnson

Pull that dry maple in before the river damp gets into it. We're on the Easton side of the Delaware, down at Scott Park where the Lehigh comes in hard and the Free Bridge lamps throw a yellow strip across the water toward Phillipsburg. Once the sun drops behind the West Ward roofs the cold comes up off the confluence like it owns the bank, and if you listen you can hear a truck shift gears on Larry Holmes Drive and a train somewhere north of us headed along the river. My name is Jonah Derr. I'm twenty-two. This is about a portable planetarium dome at Nurture Nature Center, and about a stuck gear tooth that finished a choice my mouth had already lost.

I was eighteen the April night the science club rented the inflatable dome and hauled it into the education hall at 518 Northampton Street. The Center sits a short walk from the circle and the farmers' market stalls, brick and glass on a downtown block that still smells like river fog when the wind comes wrong. Our adviser, Ms. Vargo, had booked the room for a public sky night. Parents paid five dollars at a folding table by the Science on a Sphere globe. Kids got a

stamped ticket and a photocopied star chart with the date of the show printed in the corner in Ms. Vargo's block print: APRIL 12. The Sphere turned slow in its dark corner while we inflated the dome with a box fan that rattled like a dryer with a coin in it. I held the fabric seam while Tyler walked the ring and pinned the floor skirt so nobody would trip when the lights went down.

You need to know Tyler Brandt.

Tyler was a year ahead of me at Easton Area, thick through the chest from crew, with a habit of correcting anyone who used the word miracle for weather. He believed in science the way some men believe in a locked tool chest: if the latch closes, the job is done. God, to Tyler, was a story people kept for funerals and Christmas Eve. The universe was atoms and fields and whatever the software could put on a dome. He used the word explained the way a man uses a finished sentence. Once a mechanism had a name, the case was closed.

"Once you map it, it's mapped," he told me that afternoon while we bolted the projector into its cradle in the center of the inflated room. The dome fabric hung in a white curve over our heads, seams dark where the light from the hall door cut in. "Big Bang, stellar fusion, gravity wells. You don't need a Person after that. Explained means finished. Leave the hymns for the people who can't read a chart."

I did not argue with him while we were still carrying gear. Arguing with Tyler mid-setup was like arguing with a running fan. You got noise and you got heat and the bolts still needed a wrench.

The projector was a used Digistar-style unit the club borrowed from a regional education co-op, older than the permanent Earth and Sky build the Center was raising money for, with a metal gear ring under a clear cover and a little plastic tooth that engaged the sky wheel when the software called for a season change. Ms. Vargo showed us the tooth that morning with her

fingertip on the case. "If it sticks, don't force it," she said. "Back the wheel off and free the tooth by hand. These units chew themselves if you lean on the motor." A strip of blue painter's tape on the case lid held a faded co-op inventory sticker, half peeled, with a coffee smear across the barcode. That coffee smear is one of the true things in this story, and it does no other work except sit there.

We ran a dry show at four o'clock while the Sphere still turned in the outer room. The dome went dark and the stars came up in their borrowed software order. Tyler narrated from a stool with a headset mic, naming Orion and the Dipper and the path of the ecliptic the way a good student does when he has the script cold. At the season-change cue the gear tooth caught, the wheel stuttered, and the projected sky froze with March still hanging where April should have been. Tyler cursed under his breath, killed the motor, and I reached under the cover with two fingers, freed the tooth from the plastic burr that had risen on the ring, and seated it again until the wheel turned smooth. From the door, Ms. Vargo clapped once and told us to keep those hands ready for the public hour.

The public show started at seven. The education hall filled with coats and damp shoes and the smell of popcorn somebody had burned in the staff microwave. I took tickets at the folding table until the last family went under the dome flap, tore stubs, and stacked the cash in the metal box Ms. Vargo had labeled SKY NIGHT. Then I slid in and sat on the floor with my back to the projector cradle, chart in my lap, the stamped ticket stub still warm in my hoodie pocket from where I'd tucked the extras.

Tyler opened the way he always opened. He talked about light-years and fusion and the age of the universe as if those numbers were a lid that screwed down tight. The Sphere in the outer room hummed through the wall. Outside, Northampton Street carried Friday traffic toward

the Free Bridge. Inside the dome the sky wheeled, and kids pointed, and a little girl in a pink coat asked if God put the stars up, and Tyler laughed once through the mic.

"Science put the map together," he said. "That's enough of an answer for anybody who wants a real one. Explained. Next question."

The girl went quiet. Her mother put a hand on the pink sleeve. I kept my mouth shut because the show was Tyler's and I was the tooth guy.

At the season-change cue the gear stuck again.

The sky froze on a winter belt while the chart in every lap said April. The motor whined. Tyler leaned on the control tablet the way a man leans on a stuck bolt, and the tooth made a dry click against the burr and refused to take the next notch. The projected constellations sat wrong for the date stamped on the paper. A boy in the second row said the Dipper looked tipped. Ms. Vargo called from the flap, voice low and clear: "Jonah. Hands."

I did not make a speech. Speeches do not move a projector tooth, and they do not move a friend who has already decided that a finished mechanism closes every door the mechanism never opened. I crawled to the cradle on my knees, lifted the clear cover, and put my fingers on the plastic tooth the way I had at four o'clock. The burr had raised higher from the earlier catch. The tooth sat half engaged, the wheel binding, the software still calling for a sky that the hardware would not give.

Tyler hissed from the stool. "Force it. We have a schedule. The sky is explained either way. The date on the chart is a printout. Reality is the math."

My hands stayed on the tooth. The cradle edge dug into my wrist. Heat from the projector lamp came up through the metal. I could smell warm dust and the popcorn burn from the hall.

"If I force it, we chew the ring," I said. "Ms. Vargo said so."

"Then the show dies on a wrong month and we look like we don't know what we're doing," Tyler said. "Push it. Explained is explained. A stuck tooth doesn't open a theology."

Outside the dome, through the fabric, somebody laughed in the Sphere room. A bus hissed its brakes at the curb on Northampton. The little girl in pink had gone still with her chart held flat on her knees, the APRIL 12 block print clear under the dome's leftover glow.

I backed the wheel off the way Ms. Vargo had shown us. The tooth came free in my fingers, a small white plastic piece with a worn face and a hairline crack I had not seen at four. I held it up so the lamp caught it. Then I set it in my palm and did not reseal it.

"We're done with the motor," I said, loud enough for the front rows. "We'll finish on the real sky. Charts out. Coats on. Spotting scopes are already on the rolling cart by the Pine Street door. Ms. Vargo?"

She held the flap open with her shoulder and waved the line toward the hall. "Walk them down toward Scott Park. Stay on the sidewalk. Jonah has the tooth. Tyler, bring the cart."

Tyler stared at my open hand. The cracked tooth sat there like a bad punchline. He killed the tablet, pulled the headset off, and for a second his mouth worked without sound. Then he stood and grabbed the cart handle hard enough that the scopes rattled in their foam.

We led two dozen people out of 518 Northampton into the April dark. The Center's windows threw rectangles on the sidewalk. We walked east and south toward the water, past the circle and the market block, coats zipped, charts flapping against belt loops and stroller handles. A shopkeeper on the corner was pulling a metal grate down over a window, and the grate rang once when it hit the stop. The Delaware came up cold and wide at Larry Holmes Drive, and Scott Park opened under the Free Bridge lights with the confluence dark beyond the rail. Phillipsburg's

windows sat across the water like a second, smaller map. A heron stood in the shallows below the dam and did not move when a truck crossed the bridge.

Tyler set the first spotting scope on a pad by the overlook rail. He checked the finder, swung toward Vega's neighborhood, and cursed again because the rechargeable battery pack on the mount had gone flat between afternoon check and night use. The second scope's pack held a charge. He swapped batteries with his jaw tight, thumbed the power until the mount woke, and the eyepiece found a hard white point that was not a planet and not a plane. I held the cracked tooth in my fist while he worked, and the plastic edges pressed into my palm hard enough to leave a mark.

Along the rail the line of coats thickened. Kids pressed charts flat to the metal so the wind would not take the paper. With a red flashlight held low, Ms. Vargo named what she could and kept the beam off the eyepieces. Tyler recovered his voice and started talking mechanisms again: fusion, distance, the speed of light as a ruler. He was good at it. He always had been. A father asked why the chart's April sky had not matched the dome before we walked out, and Tyler said hardware failure, then said the real sky was the proof that science still owned the night.

I stood with the ticket stub from the folding table still in my pocket and the chart in my other hand. The print said APRIL 12 in Ms. Vargo's block letters. The sky over the Delaware held what an April sky holds when the light pollution from the Free Bridge and the downtown blocks washes the faint stuff out: hard bright points, a few named shapes, and a lot of dark the chart could not fill with ink. Water slapped the concrete below the rail. Somebody's dog barked once up toward the bandshell and went quiet.

Tyler finished a sentence about stellar nurseries and turned his face toward me in the bridge light.

"You made a scene over a gear," he said, voice kept for me while the scopes took a line.
"You think a stuck tooth means the universe has a Person in it? That's a gap talking. We name the gap, we close it. That's what explained means."

I opened my hand. The tooth's cracked face caught the yellow from the bridge.

"The dome mapped a sky," I said. "The tooth failed the map mid-sentence. We came outside and the battery was dead until you swapped it. The chart still says April and the sky still does what it does whether our motor runs or not. Science is a good servant for the how. It told us the wheel was binding and the pack was flat and which way to point the tube. It did not tell us why there is a sky to map, or why a question keeps standing after the mechanism has a name. You used explained like a lid. That lid never covered the why the how left standing."

Tyler took the tooth from my palm, turned it once, and set it on the rail beside the scope base.

"Cute," he said. "You're preaching with a projector part."

"I'm telling you what my hands already did," I said. "I could have forced the ring and let the show lie about the month so your word stayed tidy. I backed it off. The how still matters. The how is not the whole sentence."

He wiped his hands on his jeans. A barge light moved slow on the Delaware toward the bend. The heron lifted and went upriver into the dark. On the New Jersey side a porch bulb blinked out and left a darker gap in the line of windows.

"I'm not converting," Tyler said, plain as a stamped ticket. "I like the maps. I don't like the Mapper. You can keep your open questions. I'll keep calling a finished mechanism a finished case."

"I know," I said. "I'm not your Holy Spirit."

Ms. Vargo called time from the rail. We capped the eyepieces, rolled the scopes back up Larry Holmes toward Northampton, and counted heads at every corner the way she had drilled us. The Center took the empty dome fabric and the projector cradle into storage. I left the cracked tooth on Ms. Vargo's desk in a paper cup with a note that said DO NOT FORCE / REPLACE RING. She taped the cup to the case beside the coffee-smeared inventory sticker and locked the closet. The key went on the ring at her belt with a soft click I still hear when I walk that block.

That night a few of us built a small fire in the ring at Scott Park the way the city allows when the wind is right and somebody brings a bucket of sand. Tyler came late with crew sweat still on his collar. He cracked a can. I kept my hands around a paper cup of gas-station coffee that had already gone lukewarm. He talked about practice and a calc test and a girl from Phillipsburg who liked the Sphere exhibit better than the stuffed birds upstairs. Then he tipped the can toward the dark where the dome had been, up the hill and west of us on Northampton.

"You still think God is hiding in a stuck gear," he said.

"I think explained has to know its job," I said. "If explained only means we named a how, then using it to shut every why is borrowing a bigger word than the tool earned. You don't live like the whys are fake. You get mad when a chart lies. Mad needs a real line. A servant that maps the sky is still a servant."

Tyler stared at the coals. A moth kept hitting the nearest bridge light and falling back and trying again. The Free Bridge hummed under a late truck, and the yellow strip on the water broke and healed and broke again.

"I still sleep fine," he said. "You keep your tooth. I'll keep my lid."

He drank. I watched the fire take a knot of maple and throw a short spark onto the brick, where it died. We did not hug it out. We did not settle the veil. The Delaware moved past us toward the bend the way it always does, and Tyler stayed Tyler, and the cracked tooth sat taped in a paper cup behind a locked closet door on Northampton Street with the coffee smear still on the sticker.

I graduated that June and took a year of community college classes while I stacked lumber at a yard on the South Side, counting board feet and listening to forklifts beep in reverse. Tyler went to a state school for engineering and sends me photos of lab benches when he remembers. Sometimes I see his car on Northampton when I walk past the Center. He lifts two fingers off the wheel. I lift two fingers back. We have not spoken about lids since the night the dome froze on the wrong month.

On nights like this, with the maple smoking and the Free Bridge humming and the confluence taking the day's heat off the bank, I keep the story short. I am not here to close the big question for you. I am here to tell you what a borrowed word sounds like in a friend's mouth when his hands are forcing a gear, and what another man's hands did with a cracked projector tooth when the sky on the cloth stopped matching the date on the chart.

Throw that other piece on. Let the fire see our faces. I like an Easton fire that shows me the bridge and the water both, and leaves the far bank dark where the light can't reach.

END